



The Lord of the Rings: The Fellowship of the Ring

A saga of hits and misses

Riding on the gravy train of Tolkein's work, Vivendi's *Fellowship of the Ring* is based more on the books than on the recently released Peter Jackson movie. You will find yourself in a visually rich Middle Earth, with control over one of three playable characters at various points in time. Aragorn, Frodo and Gandalf fight their way through hordes of wargs, wraiths and trolls, each armed with a unique style of play.



SHOWDOWN DURING SUNDOWN:
Aragorn gets down and boogies with some orcs

Entertaining and challenging, the combat serves as the central element of the game. It's great fun playing as Aragorn, with his stylish moves and a cool, quick-draw, bow-action. Gandalf is just as engaging; his repertoire of spells makes short change of any foe—orc or Balrog. While both Gandalf and Aragon can dish it out, you will find yourself avoiding confrontations (running for the exit is a frequent occurrence) while playing as Frodo. He carries weapons that force a dodge-and-counter style of combat. The hobbit can use the One Ring to render himself invisible, but this property of the Ring is almost never needed.

The levels are generally well designed, but some come across as just plain needless: they seem to have been added to either give each character enough of a role within the game, or for the sake of contributing a little more than the movie. Puzzles found within are at times easily solved while at others are a source of frustration. The in-game cinematics are badly choreographed: the



RINGS AROUND THE WRAITH:
Aragorn and Gandalf can slay the beasties

characters seem to be in a hurry to finish their dialogues and transitions from one scene to another are a bumpy ride.

Somewhat related to the movie, the game boldly sets out on a new path, attempting to present an experience that is different from, but complimentary to the film. The offering does waver from its set road: some aspects of the game have been well executed while others fall short of expectations.

Genre: Third person, action-adventure ■ **Developer:** Black Label Games ■ **Distributor:** World Wide CD Roms ■ **Phone:** 022-26973894
Web site: www.lordoftherings.com ■ **Price:** Rs 1,299 ■ **System requirements:** 600 MHz processor, 128 MB RAM, 32 MB DirectX 8 compliant video card ■ **Rating:** ★★★★★



3DS MAX 4: GROUND RULES

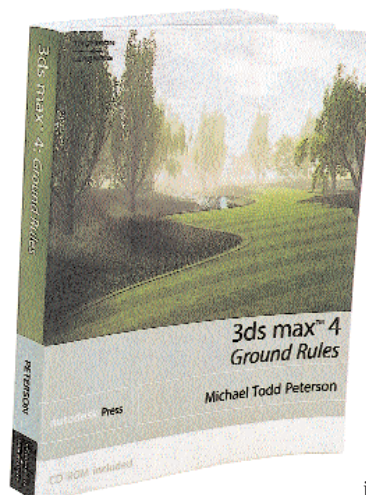
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3ds max 4: Ground Rules is a tailor-made book for beginners starting out with 3D Studio Max R4—every aspect of the software, from the basics of the user interface, to modelling, rendering, animation and special effects, is covered in a lucid and clear language.

The book does not limit itself to the basics—relatively advanced topics such as network rendering and inverse kinematics have also been covered. Complex special effects are also touched upon briefly, without going into the deep details that might baffle a new learner. The emphasis is on basic techniques, interface layout and usage, making it easier for new users

overwhelmed by 3ds max's interface to get their work done.

The accompanying CD has actual screen captures of all the operations described in the book. Organised by way of chapters, the CD has visual representations for everything the book describes. Along with the final rendered animations, these videos leave little to the imagina-



tion. On the whole, *Ground Rules* is a very wholesome book, covering all the features present in 3ds max4.

However, none of the topics are covered in depth, which makes this more of an introductory book. Recommended reading for absolute beginners venturing into the realm of 3d animation and who want to learn 3ds max in its entirety.

Publisher: Autodesk Press ■ **Contact:** Computer Bookshop ■ **Phone:** 022-22070989/22076356 ■ **Fax:** 022-2623551
E-mail: cbsbom@giabm01.vsnl.net.in ■ **Price:** Rs 1,100
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